struggle to raise two daughters after their father died, and then Léa scrambled to earn enough money to take care of them both following their mother's passing. Children seemed to be a burden, an anchor weighing one down. André came from a large family, so naturally, he would want children. She turned her head toward the window. "I don't know."

"You have plenty of time to figure it out." He paused, glanced at his sketchpad, pencil moving as he continued drawing. "A modern house should be simple and flexible. Inside, let's keep it all open with as few walls as possible. How does that sound?"

"No walls?"

"I want to see you every moment."

"What about the bathroom?"

He nodded. "You're right, we'll need a wall there." He turned to her. "And the bedrooms, too." He made quick flourishes with his hands. "But the rest—kitchen, living, dining—will all be one large space. And here, in the courtyard, windows will fold back like doors extending the space outside."

"Oh, that sounds lovely. But what sort of tree would you propose in the courtyard?"

"Olive."

"A symbol of peace?" she asked softly, liking the idea.

He nodded. "Their form is robust like a sculpture."

"I think the silvery foliage is beautiful, and they keep their leaves all winter."

He smiled. "I can see us happy living there—children running, you drawing, me designing. We have a shared vision, Rose. We will build our future together."

She let this settle within her, then she leaned forward and kissed him. Breathless, she pulled back, slightly in awe at her boldness. "If we get hungry, we can eat the olives!"

He laughed. "Or make oil." His knee brushed hers. "Maybe we'd never have to leave—our sanctuary."

"A sanctuary of peace," Rose said happily.

He put the pencil down, folded the paper into a small square, then handed it to her. "Hold on to it, Rose, and never let it go. It's our dream," he said. "If we can see it in our mind's eye, then we can bring it to life. The